46TH ANNIVERSARY

THE NEXT 100 AUTHORS

EPIC IMAGINATION

SAMHITA ARNI, 37

Author, Bengaluru

Samhita Arni was four when her father, an officer in the Indian Foreign Service, was handed a Pakistan posting. In Karachi's embassy library, she found several versions of the *Mahabharata*. Having read the text over and over again, she decided to illustrate and rewrite Vyasa's epic. Arni was 12 when her *The Mahabharata: A Child's View* was released. There was something endearing about the quirky way in which she drew *astras*, but what seemed precocious was her anti-war stance. Arni's talent only grew with time; in 2012, she found herself on the *New York Times* bestseller list with *Sita's Ramayana*. Though the illustrations were by Moyna Chitrakar's, a Patua scroll artist, Arni imagined Sita's voice and narration of the *Ramayana*. She followed up on the success of these titles with *The Missing Queen* in 2013, and *The Prince*, a period novel that hit stands in 2019. ■

–Shreevatsa Nevatia

FELINE PHILOSOPHER Arni was 31 when she rescued her first cat. She named him after a character from *Chhota Bheem*–Chutki.